

INDEPENDENT MARKET RESEARCH

UnitedStats Market & Product Strategy

Research Report

Competitive landscape · Distinctive positioning ·
Core product capabilities · Market gaps · Value proposition

PROJECT REVIEWED

cbrown564-alt/unitedstats

Prepared 22 June 2026

THESIS IN ONE PAGE

The market does not need another archive.

It needs an evidence engine.

**MARKET REALITY****The market is fragmented.**

Legacy archives own historical lookup; live apps own match-day utility; official media owns emotion; open feeds own raw infrastructure.

**WHITE SPACE****No obvious leader combines depth, discovery and trust.**

The open quadrant is deep club history with modern question-led interaction and evidence behind every claim.

**RECOMMENDED CATEGORY****Queryable club history.**

More distinctively: the evidence engine for Manchester United history.

6,027

MATCHES

126

SEASONS

6,022

LINE-UPS

72,095

APPEARANCES

PRIMARY VALUE PROPOSITION

**Ask any question about Manchester United history.
Get a sourced answer - and every match behind it.**

Prepared

22 June 2026

Project reviewed

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Research basis

Repository documentation and public product pages available on the review date.

REPORT NAVIGATION

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READING GUIDE

The report moves from market context and competitive alternatives to product differentiation, positioning, execution priorities and defensibility. The central recommendation is concentrated in Sections 9-11.

Executive summary

UnitedStats is entering a real but fragmented market. There are already products that are excellent at one of five jobs:

1. **Preserving Manchester United's statistical history** — especially MUFCInfo.
2. **Providing standardised historical football records** — 11v11 and StatBunker.
3. **Serving live and current-season football data** — FotMob, Sofascore and BeSoccer.
4. **Explaining the club through official stories and video** — Manchester United's official site and MUTV.
5. **Supplying raw football data to developers** — OpenFootball, football-data.org, API-Football and Sportmonks.

No obvious competitor combines all of the following:

- club-specific historical depth;
- a modern, answer-first interface;
- visible source and coverage information;
- an evidence path from every claim to the underlying matches;
- fair, clearly defined comparisons across eras;
- an open, versioned dataset and public API;
- shareable outputs for fans, writers and creators.

That combination is UnitedStats' opportunity.

The most important strategic conclusion is that **"the most complete archive" is not sufficient positioning**. MUFCInfo already claims more than 6,026 competitive matches, 969 player profiles and over 5,953 first-team line-ups. UnitedStats itself reports 6,027 matches and line-ups for 6,022 matches. The products are therefore close enough in raw breadth that users will not switch merely because one database has a few more rows.

The stronger category is:

The evidence engine for Manchester United history.

The recommended customer promise is:

Ask any question about Manchester United history. Get a sourced answer — and every match behind it.

This shifts the product from being another database to being the fastest and most trustworthy way to settle a debate, test a football myth, compare two eras, verify a claim, or find the evidence for a story.

The next product investments should therefore concentrate on:

- turning search, Questions, Compare and Explore into one coherent discovery journey;
- redesigning comparison and exploration around the answer rather than the form;
- making every result easy to share, cite and embed; ✓
- creating a habit loop around "on this day" and "what changed after the latest match";
- turning the existing provenance model into a visible correction and contribution workflow;
- adding natural-language access only as a deterministic query layer over the database, never as unsupported AI punditry.

UnitedStats should not try to beat FotMob or Sofascore at live scores, Transfermarkt at transfer rumours and market values, or the official club at licensed video. Its defensible asset is the combination of a curated historical corpus, provenance, identity resolution, definitions, query logic and evidence-linked presentation.

1. Product baseline

The repository describes UnitedStats as the exhaustive history of Manchester United: every match, every competition, with progressively deeper line-up and goal-contribution data. Its architecture is unusually well suited to a trustworthy historical product:

- canonical JSON stored in Git;
- a compiled SQLite database;
- deterministic validation and precomputation;
- scheduled result updates through GitHub Actions;
- a read-only Next.js interface;
- a public API and downloadable data;
- explicit code and dataset licences.

At the reviewed snapshot, the repository reports:

- **6,027 matches across 126 seasons;**
- complete competitive-result coverage across the club's history;
- attendance for approximately 98% of matches;
- scorer data for approximately 99% of matches in which United scored;
- **6,022 matches with full United starting line-ups;**
- **72,095 recorded United appearances;**
- manager attribution, league positions, competitions, stadiums and opponents;
- 975 match-attributed assists from 2012–13 onwards, plus a separately labelled curated historical aggregate lane.

The current product is already more than a static archive. It includes:

- match, season, player, manager and opponent pages;
- hybrid entity and shaped-query search;
- nine myth-testing question modules;
- Elo history and prospective probability modelling;
- player, manager and era comparison;
- streak detection;
- a group-by explorer;
- evidence links from aggregates back to matches;
- source and coverage notes;
- a data ledger, correction guidance, API and exports.

The repository's own product north star is strong: pattern discovery for statistics-heavy Manchester United fans with researcher-grade trust expectations. The phrase "floodlit match-night ledger" also establishes a useful design ambition: emotional and atmospheric, but never at the expense of clarity.

The main internal weakness is not missing functionality. It is **coherence and product hierarchy**. The roadmap and audits already acknowledge that Compare and Explore feel like utilities, that navigation has become crowded, and that engagement, distribution and contribution workflows remain underdeveloped. The market research supports that diagnosis.

2. Market definition

UnitedStats participates in several overlapping markets rather than one clean category.

2.1 The direct market: club-specific historical archives

These products exist to preserve and retrieve the record of one club. Users arrive with questions such as:

- Who played in a particular match?
- What is United's record against an opponent?
- How many goals did a player score?
- Which manager had the best record?
- What happened on this date?
- Which players made their debut together?

MUFCInfo is the principal active competitor. StretfordEnd was an important historical reference but its domain is now for sale.

2.2 General football-statistics databases

11v11, StatBunker and similar databases standardise the record across clubs and competitions. Their strength is breadth and conventional statistical retrieval rather than a deep, emotionally resonant club product.

2.3 Live-score and current-performance platforms

FotMob, Sofascore and BeSoccer are designed around the next match, the live match and the current season. They set users' expectations for speed, polish, mobile interaction, line-ups, ratings, notifications and visual statistics. They are not primarily designed to answer deep historical questions.

2.4 Transfer, squad and football-market databases

Transfermarkt's centre of gravity is squad history, transfers, market values, contracts and community-maintained football identities. It has extensive historical season navigation, but historical match evidence is not its defining proposition.

2.5 Official storytelling and media

Manchester United's own channels own the strongest brand, archive footage, interviews, documentaries and official narrative. They are authoritative and emotionally rich, but they are not an open, queryable research database.

2.6 Encyclopedic and open-data substitutes

Wikipedia often satisfies a one-off search for a record, rivalry or season. OpenFootball and public APIs satisfy developers who want machine-readable fixtures. These alternatives are open or accessible, but the information is fragmented, raw or difficult to interrogate.

3. User jobs and audiences

The strongest product strategy begins with jobs, not feature categories.

Primary audience: the statistics-heavy supporter

Job: "Help me answer or test a specific question about United without spending an hour assembling evidence."

Typical triggers include an argument with another supporter, a memory of a match, a claim in commentary, or curiosity about whether a current run is historically unusual.

This audience values completeness, speed, clarity and the ability to inspect the matches behind a number.

Secondary audience: writers, podcasters and fan creators

Job: "Give me a defensible fact, an interesting angle and a visual I can publish."

This audience needs clean citations, transparent definitions, shareable cards, exportable tables and stable links. It is potentially UnitedStats' most powerful distribution channel because each creator turns the database into public discovery.

Secondary audience: researchers and developers

Job: "Give me a reproducible, licensed dataset and a clear way to query it."

This audience values versioning, schema quality, provenance, downloads, APIs and predictable definitions more than decorative presentation.

Growth audience: nostalgic and casual supporters

Job: "Help me rediscover people, matches and eras I care about."

This audience is less likely to begin with a technical query. It responds to "on this day", anniversaries, player stories, famous runs and guided trails.

Possible future audience: contributors and historians

Job: "Let me improve the historical record without fighting the schema or breaking the site."

This audience becomes important once the correction process is made visible and low-friction.

4. Competitive landscape

4.1 MUFCInfo — the closest direct competitor

Positioning: the definitive fan-built Manchester United statistical archive.

MUFCInfo says it was established in 1996 and is the original and oldest Manchester United statistics site on the internet. It publicly offers:

- more than 6,026 competitive matches;
- more than 969 player profiles;
- more than 5,953 first-team match-day line-ups;
- searchable match and player archives;
- goals, appearances, penalties, hat-tricks, own goals and red cards;
- season, opponent, manager, stadium and competition records;
- transfers, goalkeepers, clean sheets, attendances and honours;
- “on this day”, birthdays and debuts;
- side-by-side player comparison.

Distinctive strength: extraordinary club-specific breadth accumulated over decades. It is the benchmark for archival completeness and obscure record categories.

Weakness relative to the UnitedStats opportunity: its public product is primarily a large navigable archive. It does not prominently position itself around versioned open data, a public API, explicit facet-level coverage, evidence-linked argument modules or modern exploratory visualisation.

Strategic implication: UnitedStats should treat MUFCInfo with respect and explicit attribution where it is a source. It should not claim that no comprehensive archive exists. The differentiation must be **how the record is interrogated, trusted and reused**.

4.2 StretfordEnd — the legacy vacancy

StretfordEnd historically occupied the role of a deep Manchester United record, and UnitedStats explicitly describes itself as a modern successor. The domain is currently offered for sale.

Distinctive significance: it demonstrates that there is genuine heritage and affinity around independent United archives.

Market implication: there is an opening for continuity, but “successor to a beloved old database” is an origin story rather than a complete value proposition. The product still needs a current, outcome-focused promise.

4.3 11v11 — standardised historical reference

11v11 offers a club overview, honours, players, matches, head-to-head records, Premier League statistics, league tables, results, fixtures, squads, staff and transfers.

Distinctive strength: standardisation across English football and the credibility of a traditional football-statistics reference.

Weakness relative to UnitedStats: it is oriented towards conventional lookup and cross-club coverage. It does not provide the same club-specific provenance model, guided questions or open-data proposition.

4.4 StatBunker — powerful tables across competitions

StatBunker positions around all-time statistics, managers and a very wide range of domestic, continental and international competitions.

Distinctive strength: sortable, highly granular statistical tables and broad competition coverage.

Weakness relative to UnitedStats: utilitarian presentation, limited emotional connection and little emphasis on a source trail from interpretation to individual matches.

Lesson: expert users tolerate density when the controls are powerful. UnitedStats should retain advanced filtering, but wrap it in answer-first defaults.

4.5 Transfermarkt — the football labour-market database

Transfermarkt combines:

- current and historical squads;
- season navigation extending deep into club history;
- market values;
- transfers and financial balances;
- player identities, positions, ages and nationalities;
- scorer and assist summaries;
- a community of moderators and data scouts.

Distinctive strength: transfer history, market-value authority, entity breadth and a large correction network.

Weakness relative to UnitedStats: its core product is the football market and squad lifecycle, not transparent historical match reasoning.

Lesson: contribution systems can become a moat. UnitedStats should turn corrections from a footer invitation into a first-class workflow.

4.6 BeSoccer — the broad football portal

BeSoccer combines matches, live information, transfers, squads, tables, media, news, career histories, competitions, injuries, honours and historical pages.

Distinctive strength: breadth, global coverage and a one-stop football portal.

Weakness relative to UnitedStats: broad portals struggle to deliver deep, distinctive club-history experiences. Their surface area is an advantage for general discovery but a disadvantage for conceptual clarity.

Lesson: UnitedStats should resist becoming an “everything United” portal. Focus is part of the differentiation.

4.7 FotMob — the polished current-season companion

FotMob's team experience centres on following the club, calendar sync, fixtures, table, squad, player and team statistics, transfers and history.

Distinctive strength: excellent current-season UX, mobile habits and match-day interaction.

Weakness relative to UnitedStats: historical depth and evidence-linked research are secondary to live/current usage.

Lesson: users will compare UnitedStats' interaction quality with FotMob even when the data job is different. Search, loading, mobile controls, charts and sharing must feel contemporary.

4.8 Sofascore — live breadth and algorithmic performance

Sofascore provides live scores, minute-by-minute statistics, player performance data, favourites and automatically updated results across more than 500 competitions. Its Manchester United page exposes the last 100 matches and a proprietary form graph based on recent matches and statistics.

Distinctive strength: live breadth, automatic updates, algorithmic ratings and an established follow/notification habit.

Weakness relative to UnitedStats: the club page's historical horizon is shallow compared with a complete archive, and proprietary model outputs are not an evidence trail through 140 years of matches.

Lesson: UnitedStats should not compete on live event frequency. It can compete on the more distinctive post-match question: **"What did this result change in the club's history?"**

4.9 Manchester United official site and MUTV — authority and emotion

The official site organises history by decade, Munich remembrance and trophies. MUTV provides club-owned video and editorial media.

Distinctive strength: official authority, brand, interviews, footage and emotional storytelling.

Weakness relative to UnitedStats: the history is curated rather than freely queryable, and the underlying statistical record is not offered as an open evidence system.

Lesson: UnitedStats should complement, not imitate, the official site. It can link users from a statistical finding to licensed or official context where appropriate, while retaining a clear non-affiliation statement.

4.10 Wikipedia — the default fragmented substitute

Wikipedia has dedicated pages for club records, seasons, players, rivalries and league records by opponent. Broad searches for United history frequently surface these pages.

Distinctive strength: free access, strong search visibility, citations and extensive community coverage.

Weakness relative to UnitedStats: information is split across many pages, definitions vary, data is difficult to query, and aggregates do not naturally expose a reproducible match set.

Lesson: UnitedStats should create indexable, canonical pages for real questions, not hide all discovery behind a client-side search box.

4.11 Open data and commercial APIs — infrastructure, not the finished experience

OpenFootball offers public-domain English football data and buildable JSON, CSV and database outputs. football-data.org, API-Football and Sportmonks provide varying combinations of fixtures, standings, line-ups, events, statistics, predictions and live scores.

Distinctive strength: machine-readable current football data and developer convenience.

Weakness relative to UnitedStats: generic providers do not deliver a curated, identity-resolved and source-explained Manchester United historical corpus. Historical depth and redistribution rights also vary.

Lesson: fixtures and current-season feeds are increasingly commoditised. UnitedStats' moat is the historical integration and interpretation layer above those feeds.

5. Competitive scorecard

The following is an analyst assessment of public positioning, not a claim about every hidden or paid feature.

DEPTH PARITY

Raw breadth is not enough.

Specialist archives already approach UnitedStats on match and line-up coverage, so a few extra rows will not create switching value.

INTERACTION GAP

Modern UX sits elsewhere.

Live products set expectations for speed and polish, but they are not built to answer deep historical questions.

TRUST MOAT

Evidence is the differentiator.

Visible coverage, match trails and reusable data are rarely delivered together in a fan-grade product.

DECISION RULE

Do not fight for “largest archive” or “best live app.” Own evidence-backed discovery.

THE SCORECARD TESTS SIX DIMENSIONS

01 Historical depth

04 Evidence transparency

02 Live utility

05 Reusable data

03 Question-led discovery

06 Emotional storytelling

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

Competitive scorecard

An analyst assessment of public positioning. Colour indicates relative strength within each market dimension, not an audit of every paid or logged-in feature.

Product category	Club-history depth	Live/current utility	Question-led discovery	Evidence / coverage transparency	Open / reusable data	Emotional storytelling
UnitedStats, current	Very high	Low-medium	High	Very high	Very high	Medium-high
MUFCInfo	Very high	Medium	Medium	Low-medium	Low	Medium
11v11 / StatBunker	High	Medium	Low	Low	Low	Low
Transfermarkt / BeSoccer	Medium-high	High	Medium	Low	Low	Medium
FotMob / Sofascore	Low-medium	Very high	Medium for current form	Low	Low	Medium
Official site / MUTV	Selective	High for current content	Low	Official authority; limited row-level evidence	Low	Very high
Wikipedia / open datasets	High but fragmented	Medium	Low	Medium-high	High	Low-medium

FINDING 01

Archive depth is contested.

MUFCInfo and other historical references already make completeness a difficult standalone claim.

FINDING 02

Discovery is the opening.

Question-led exploration remains weak across specialist archives and general databases.

FINDING 03

Trust plus openness is rare.

Evidence trails, coverage transparency and reusable data form the strongest combined advantage.

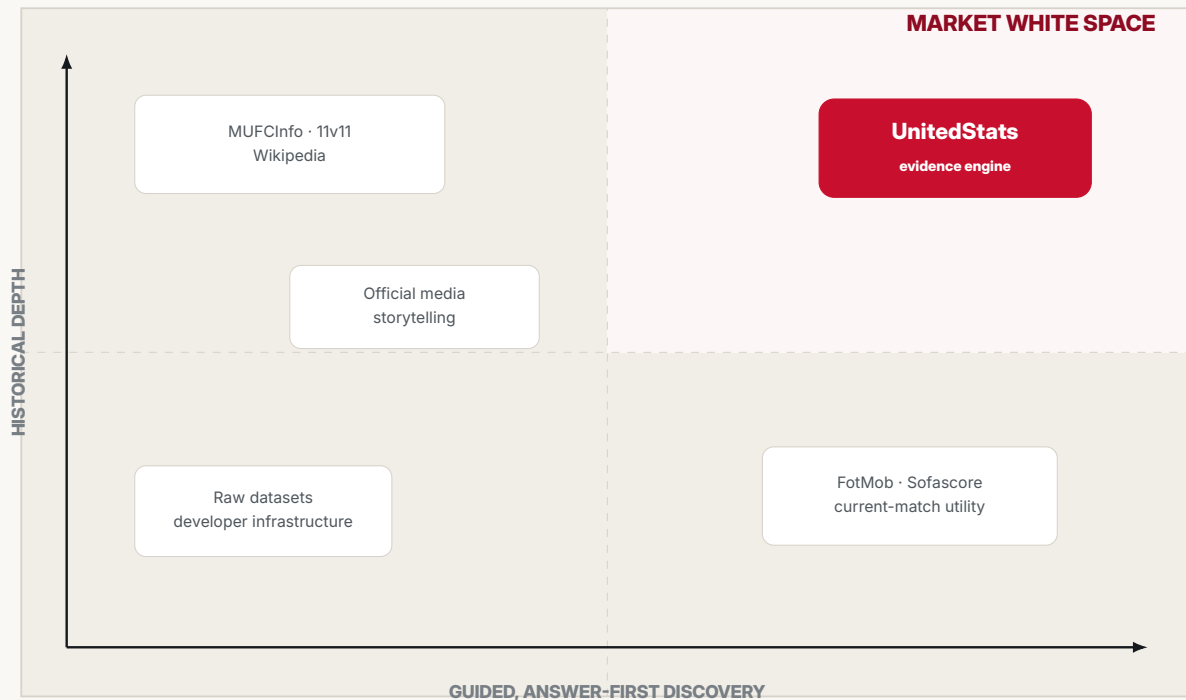
White-space signal. UnitedStats is the only proposition in this set designed to combine deep club history, guided discovery, visible evidence and reusable open data.

White-space conclusion

On a map with **historical depth** on one axis and **guided, answer-first discovery** on the other:

- MUFCInfo, 11v11 and Wikipedia sit towards deep history but reference-style navigation.
- FotMob and Sofascore sit towards guided interaction but current/live data.
- raw datasets sit in the infrastructure corner.
- the official site sits in emotional storytelling rather than queryable evidence.

UnitedStats can own the relatively empty quadrant of **deep historical evidence plus modern guided discovery**.



Strategic opportunity: combine the archive depth of specialist databases with the guided interaction of modern football products - while making evidence and coverage explicit.

6. What distinguishes a good product from a great one

6.1 Data coverage

Good: complete results, basic match metadata, player totals and regular updates.

Great: every field has a definition, source, confidence or coverage window; partial data never masquerades as complete data; identities and competition rules are normalised across eras.

UnitedStats implication: this is already a major strength. Coverage notes should remain visible at interpretation points and become even easier to understand.

6.2 Search and retrieval

Good: search for a player, opponent, season or match.

Great: express an intent such as "United's record away to Arsenal under Ferguson" and receive an immediate, reproducible answer with the exact filter set and underlying matches.

UnitedStats implication: evolve the hybrid search into the main product interface. Natural language should compile into known entities, metrics and SQL/filter templates.

6.3 Analytics

Good: charts, record tables and leaderboards.

Great: each module begins with a clear question, states the result, defines the slice, shows uncertainty or missing coverage, and provides the match trail.

UnitedStats implication: the Questions modules already demonstrate the right model. Compare and Explore should be redesigned to the same standard.

6.4 Comparison

Good: place two players or managers side by side.

Great: compare only meaningful shared metrics; disclose coverage differences; adjust or contextualise for era, match volume, competition mix and rule changes; let the user inspect each side's evidence.

UnitedStats implication: build "fairness" into the comparison model rather than treating comparison as a visual table.

6.5 Trust

Good: an About page lists data sources.

Great: the source and scope appear exactly where they affect interpretation; corrections are versioned; users can inspect what changed and why.

UnitedStats implication: turn Git's internal advantage into a user-visible trust product: source trail, change history, correction proposal and validation result.

6.6 Freshness

Good: new results appear quickly.

Great: the product explains what the new result changed — a streak ended, an opponent record moved, an era ranking changed, a player entered a list.

UnitedStats implication: build a post-match "history changed" digest rather than a live-score centre.

6.7 User experience

Good: responsive pages, clear tables, usable filters and fast load times.

Great: the product leads with the answer, hides complexity until needed, preserves expert controls, and creates emotional texture without compromising legibility.

UnitedStats implication: the "floodlit ledger" is a sound direction. Era markers, honours, people and restrained historical imagery can add atmosphere, but visual noise should not dilute the evidence.

6.8 Distribution

Good: every page has a stable URL and a share button.

Great: a user can export a citation-ready statistic, chart or evidence card with the definition, date and source scope embedded.

UnitedStats implication: creator tooling is one of the clearest unoccupied opportunities.

6.9 Community and correction

Good: users can email an error.

Great: a user can flag a specific field, propose a correction, attach a source, preview the diff and see validation status.

UnitedStats implication: the existing canonical JSON and CI pipeline make this unusually feasible.

6.10 Platform value

Good: downloadable CSV or JSON.

Great: documented APIs, reproducible query URLs, embeddable charts, versioned releases and a clear data-change log.

UnitedStats implication: the foundation exists; packaging and developer experience are the remaining work.

7. Market gaps

Gap 1: Answers rather than archives

Most historical products make users navigate tables until they infer an answer. The unmet need is a product that accepts the question and returns the finding, definition and evidence together.

Gap 2: Transparent uncertainty

Football databases often present clean totals even when scorer, assist, line-up or event coverage is incomplete. UnitedStats' coverage ledger is differentiated, but it should become part of the product language rather than a specialist caveat.

 A useful convention would be:

- **Complete** — all eligible matches in the selected slice.
- **Strong** — high coverage; conclusion unlikely to change.
- **Partial** — useful directional result with meaningful missing data.
- **Unsupported** — the dataset cannot answer reliably.

Gap 3: Fair cross-era comparison

"Best ever" comparisons are usually raw totals or win rates. They rarely account for:

- number of matches per season;
- substitution rules;
- points systems;
- competition access;
- opponent strength;
- role and position changes;
- incomplete assist or event data;
- differences between official, wartime and friendly matches.

UnitedStats can win trust by making era context explicit and offering both raw and normalised views.

Gap 4: A creator-grade evidence workflow

There is no obvious mainstream tool optimised for the workflow:

1. find an interesting United claim;
2. verify it;
3. open the matches;
4. generate a clean visual;

5. copy a citation;
6. publish.

This is both a product gap and a distribution strategy.

Gap 5: Historical relevance after every current match

Live apps answer “what is happening?” Historical archives answer “what happened?” The missing bridge is:

“What did tonight’s match mean in the full history of Manchester United?”

Examples include:

- first win at a ground in a decade;
- longest scoring or unbeaten run;
- a manager’s first-ten ranking;
- a player moving up a goals or appearances list;
- a rare scoreline;
- an opponent record changing.

Gap 6: Habit-forming historical discovery

MUFCInfo offers “on this day”, birthdays and debuts. UnitedStats’ repository parks similar engagement ideas. A well-designed daily historical feed is an efficient way to serve casual fans without becoming a news site.

Gap 7: A scalable correction network

Transfermarkt demonstrates the value of community data scouts. Wikipedia demonstrates the power of visible edit histories. Fan archives often depend on one maintainer. UnitedStats can create a more durable contribution model through structured corrections and automated validation.

Gap 8: Open data with a fan-grade interface

OpenFootball is reusable but raw. Fan sites are usable but generally not openly versioned. UnitedStats can bridge those worlds.

Gap 9: Emotional design without editorial overreach

The official club owns the richest media, while database sites can feel clinical. There is room for an interface that evokes eras, nights, grounds and people without inventing narratives or making unsupported claims.

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Strengths

- Near-complete match and line-up coverage.
- Versioned canonical data and deterministic build process.
- Explicit source and coverage model.
- Existing API and downloadable releases.
- Question modules and evidence links already express the correct product thesis.
- Strong operational economics: static/read-heavy architecture and automated updates.
- Clear design principles and disciplined internal audits.
- Data is repairable through ordinary code-review workflows.

Weaknesses

- The name "UnitedStats" can sound generic and table-oriented.
- The product surface is broad, with multiple discovery routes competing for attention.
- Compare and Explore do not yet meet the answer-first design bar.
- Limited habit and distribution mechanisms.
- Historical assist and event detail is constrained by source availability.
- No large visible contributor community yet.
- The product cannot match licensed live event data or official video.

Opportunities

- Own "evidence-backed Manchester United history" as a category.
- Serve writers and creators with shareable, citation-ready outputs.
- Capture long-tail search demand with canonical question pages.
- Turn every new match into a historical-change story.
- Build an active correction network around the open dataset.
- Offer a trusted query API and embeds.
- Later apply the system to the women's team, academy, or other clubs after the United product is proven.

Threats

- MUFCInfo's depth and long-standing reputation.
- Search engines or general AI answering simple factual queries directly. *
- Data-source changes, rate limits and licensing constraints.
- Club trademarks, media rights and non-affiliation requirements.
- Overexpansion into live scores, news, transfers or too many routes.
- AI-generated answers undermining trust if they are not deterministic.
- A single-maintainer bottleneck for historical corrections.

9. Recommended positioning

Category

Queryable club history or, more distinctively, **a club-history evidence engine**.

"Statistics database" describes the machinery. "Evidence engine" describes the user outcome and the trust advantage.

Positioning statement

For Manchester United supporters, writers and researchers who need more than trivia, UnitedStats is the evidence engine for the club's complete history. Unlike legacy archives that list records or live-score apps built around today, it turns a versioned match database into sourced answers, fair comparisons and discovery trails — with every number linked to the matches behind it.

Primary value proposition

Ask any question about Manchester United history. Get a sourced answer — and every match behind it.

Supporting proof points

- Every competitive match from Newton Heath to today.
- Full line-ups for almost the entire record.
- Coverage shown where it affects the answer.
- Every aggregate links back to evidence.
- Open, versioned data with API and downloads.
- Updated automatically after new matches.

Alternative taglines

- **Every match. Every era. Show me the evidence.**
- **140 years of United, queryable.**
- **The open evidence base for Manchester United history.**
- **Settle the argument with the matches behind it.**
- **United history, answered.**

The first value proposition is the strongest because it names the user action, output and trust mechanism in one sentence.

10. Recommended product experience

10.1 Homepage

The homepage should behave less like a portal and more like an answer engine.

Headline:

Ask United's history.

Subhead:

Every competitive match since Newton Heath. Sourced answers, era-aware comparisons and the evidence behind every number.

Primary control:

A large question/search field.

Example prompts:

- Did Ferguson's teams really score more late goals?
- Who had the better first 50 matches: Busby or Ferguson?
- United's record away to Arsenal in Europe weeks.
- Rooney versus Charlton, season by season.
- Which opponents ended the most unbeaten runs?

Trust strip:

6,027 matches · 6,022 line-ups · coverage shown · open dataset.

Below the hero, use three routes rather than a long feature list:

- **Ask a question**
- **Explore the record**
- **Discover a person or era**

10.2 Answer page anatomy

Every generated or curated answer should follow the same structure:

1. **The answer** — one clear sentence and primary number.
2. **Definition** — exactly what was counted.
3. **Confidence/coverage** — complete, strong, partial or unsupported.
4. **Context** — benchmark, era or comparison.
5. **Evidence** — match list, player seasons or opponent meetings.
6. **Related questions** — the next useful cuts.
7. **Share/export** — card, image, CSV, citation and stable URL.
8. **Correct this** — field-specific contribution entry point.

10.3 Discovery information architecture

The current Questions, Compare and Explore routes should become one conceptual area called **Discover**.

Possible structure:

- **Featured questions** — editorially selected and evergreen.
- **Compare** — people, managers and eras.
- **Build a cut** — expert group-by/filter tool.

- **Runs and records** — streaks and unusual sequences.

This reduces top-level navigation while preserving expert capabilities.

10.4 Comparison redesign

A great comparison should open with a conclusion, not two selectors.

Example:

Ferguson leads Busby on overall win rate, but the gap narrows after normalising for opponent strength and competition mix.

Then show:

- shared-scope metrics;
- raw and contextualised views;
- metric-level coverage;
- era annotations;
- evidence links for each side;
- "where each led" summary;
- related questions.

10.5 "History changed" post-match digest

After each update, automatically generate a page or module containing only deterministic changes:

- records entered or extended;
- streaks started or ended;
- player rank changes;
- opponent and manager milestones;
- unusual scoreline or venue facts;
- Elo movement and historical percentile.

This is a high-value bridge between the current season and the archive.

10.6 Creator mode

A creator should be able to export:

- a square social card;
- a landscape article graphic;
- an embeddable chart;
- a CSV of the evidence;
- a citation block containing metric definition, coverage and retrieval date.

The visual should always carry the scope, avoiding context-free viral statistics.

10.7 Correction workflow

Add "Suggest a correction" to matches, players and events. The flow should capture:

- affected field;
- proposed value;
- source;
- explanation;
- optional attachment or archive reference.

The system can then produce a structured issue or pull request, run validation, preview the data diff and show status publicly.

11. Product priorities

Now: sharpen the wedge

1. **Reframe the product around the question-and-evidence promise.**
2. **Group Questions, Compare and Explore under one Discover entry.**
3. **Redesign Compare and Explore to lead with a finding.**
4. **Create a universal answer-page pattern.**
5. **Add shareable evidence cards and citation export.**
6. **Launch “what changed in history?” after each match.**
7. **Add a lightweight on-this-day module.**
8. **Make the correction call to action field-specific.**

Next: build the habit and platform

1. **Natural-language query compiler** over deterministic templates and SQL.
2. **Saved questions and alerts** when a new match changes the answer.
3. **Creator workspaces** for saved cuts, graphics and embeds.
4. **Documented API explorer**, versioning and example notebooks.
5. **Public data change log** with source and correction history.
6. **Related-question recommendations** based on entities and filters, not opaque generative claims.

Later: expand carefully

1. Women's-team history using the same trust model.
2. Academy and reserve-team records where sources permit.
3. Reusable club-history engine for another club.
4. Partnerships with historians, authors, fanzines or museums.
5. Paid service layers for high-volume API, alerts and publishing tools.

Explicit non-priorities

- building a live-score centre;
- transfer rumours and speculative market values;
- generic United news aggregation;
- unsupported generative match narratives;
- broad multi-club expansion before the United experience is coherent;
- licensed advanced metrics without sustainable rights;
- adding new top-level routes before simplifying the information architecture.

12. Go-to-market strategy

12.1 Long-tail search

Create canonical, indexable answer pages for questions supporters already search:

- record against each opponent;
- biggest wins and defeats;
- every manager's first ten or first 50;
- longest unbeaten, scoring and clean-sheet runs;
- player comparisons;
- rivalry records;
- "on this day" pages;
- scoreline and venue histories;
- post-European-match performance;
- records by decade and era.

Each page should expose the definition and match evidence, making it more useful than a copied snippet.

12.2 Creator seeding

Recruit a small group of United writers, podcasters, fan-channel hosts and statisticians. Give them:

- early creator exports;
- a way to request a query;
- embeddable cards;
- attribution links;
- correction access.

The goal is not paid endorsement. It is to make UnitedStats the source behind interesting, defensible claims.

12.3 Post-match distribution

Publish a concise "History changed" card after every competitive match. This can become a repeatable content format without turning the project into a news operation.

12.4 Community credibility

Publicise:

- data releases;
- correction merges;
- newly completed historical coverage;
- source investigations;
- unresolved gaps.

Transparency itself becomes content and builds trust with historians and technical users.

12.5 Partnerships: Potential partners include fanzines, supporter organisations, authors, football-history communities, museums and data-journalism educators. The offer is not merely data; it is reproducible evidence and interactive history.

13. Business-model options

The open dataset is a strategic advantage, so the core historical facts should remain free. Monetisation should focus on convenience, workflow and service.

Free core

- all public pages and answers;
- evidence trails;
- standard downloads;
- reasonable API access;
- correction participation.

Optional supporter or creator tier

- saved questions;
- automatic record-change alerts;
- high-resolution exports;
- custom-branded or publication-ready cards;
- private collections and notes;
- bulk query/export;
- higher API limits;
- embeddable interactive charts.

Institutional or media tier

- managed API access;
- service-level support;
- custom historical research;
- bespoke embeds;
- data integration and archival consulting.

Other models

- memberships or donations;
- ethical sponsorship of the project or a data-release series;
- grants for digital heritage or open data.

Because the dataset is openly licensed, the sustainable model is **selling tools and reliability around the data, not restricting access to the facts.**

14. Defensibility

The raw results are not the moat. Many sources can provide them.



The defensible system is the compound asset:

1. **Canonical corpus** — a complete, normalised club record.
2. **Identity resolution** — players, opponents, competitions, managers and grounds across changing names and eras.
3. **Provenance graph** — where each facet came from and what it covers.
4. **Definitions** — official versus friendly, appearances, assists, own goals, shoot-outs and era rules.
5. **Query layer** — reliable templates that convert fan questions into reproducible slices.
6. **Evidence UX** — every claim links to the underlying record.
7. **Correction history** — community improvements with validation and review.
8. **Distribution graph** — citations, embeds and creator links that point back to canonical answers.

A general AI can repeat a statistic. It is much harder to reproduce a trusted, versioned answer with the exact match set, definitions and source history.

15. Risks and mitigations

Data licensing and source continuity

Risk: third-party sites change access, licences or page structures.

Mitigation: maintain per-source contracts, caches and provenance; prefer redistributable sources; isolate aggregate-only lanes; preserve manual correction paths.

AI hallucination

Risk: natural-language features produce plausible but unsupported answers.

Mitigation: use AI only to classify intent and map entities. Calculations must be deterministic. Refuse or downgrade questions the data cannot support.

Definition disputes

Risk: supporters disagree about official matches, wartime fixtures, shoot-outs, assists or manager attribution.

Mitigation: publish definitions, allow scope toggles and expose the exact match set.

Product sprawl

Risk: every interesting cut becomes a new route.

Mitigation: one answer template, one discovery area and reusable query primitives. Promote only high-frequency journeys.

Brand and media rights

Risk: confusion with the official club or use of protected media.

Mitigation: clear non-affiliation language, restrained club-coded design, licensed/open images and links to official media rather than unauthorised hosting.

Maintainer concentration

Risk: data quality and operations depend on one person.

Mitigation: documented ingest paths, CI validation, structured corrections, contributor roles and release procedures.

16. Metrics

North-star metric

Weekly completed evidence sessions: a user receives an answer and either inspects, shares, exports or saves its evidence.

This is better than page views because it measures the product's real job.

Activation

- percentage of new visitors who submit a question or choose a guided prompt;
- query-to-valid-answer success rate;
- time from landing to first evidence-backed answer.

Trust

- percentage of answer views that open the evidence trail;
- citation/export usage;
- correction submissions and resolution time;
- share of analytics with complete or strong coverage;
- number of unresolved high-severity data gaps.

Retention

- repeat question sessions;
- saved-question return rate;
- on-this-day engagement;
- alert opens after new matches.

Distribution

- share-card creation rate;
- inbound visits from creator embeds and citations;
- organic entrances to canonical question pages;
- percentage of shared pages that lead to a second exploration.

Operational quality

- time from final whistle to validated data update;
- validation and golden-test pass rate;
- source-parser failure rate;
- percentage of new matches with line-up, scorer and event facets completed.

17. Final recommendation

UnitedStats should not present itself primarily as a bigger historical database. It should present itself as the product that **turns the complete record into trustworthy answers.**

The most compelling strategic expression is:

UnitedStats is the open evidence engine for Manchester United history. Ask a question, compare any era, and inspect every match behind the answer.

This positioning is credible because the repository already contains the difficult foundations: comprehensive data, versioning, validation, coverage notes, evidence links, question modules, comparisons and an API. The next stage is not a larger feature list. It is packaging those assets into one unmistakable user journey:



Question → answer → definition → confidence → evidence → share or correct.

If UnitedStats executes that loop exceptionally well, it can be more useful than a legacy archive, more trustworthy than a generic AI answer, more historically ambitious than a live-score app and more reusable than an official editorial site.

Research method and source notes

This report used a public-product review rather than private traffic, revenue or user-research data. Competitor features may vary by device, region, subscription or login state.

Repository material reviewed

- UnitedStats README
- Architecture
- Roadmap
- Surface Inventory
- Visual Audit

Public products reviewed

- MUFCInfo home, archive, comparison and site information
- StretfordEnd domain page
- 11v11 Manchester United pages
- StatBunker
- Transfermarkt Manchester United club profile
- BeSoccer Manchester United team page
- FotMob Manchester United team page
- Sofascore Manchester United team page
- Manchester United official history pages and MUTV
- Wikipedia Manchester United record, season and rivalry pages
- OpenFootball England repository
- football-data.org
- API-Football
- Sportmonks Football API

UNITEDSTATS

Every match. Every era. Show me the evidence.

Market & Product Strategy Research Report
22 June 2026